

Roost

AI-Enhanced Features — Addressing the Student Accommodation Problem

South African students, particularly those relying on NSFAS funding, face a housing market marked by scarce verified listings, rampant rental scams, and mismatched subsidy eligibility. Roost proposes the following AI-driven capabilities to directly target these pain points.

1. Scam & Fraud Detection

- **Duplicate listing detection:** Flag suspicious listings by identifying duplicate photos reused across multiple ads, or prices significantly below market rate for the area.
- **Document verification:** Use OCR combined with authenticity checks to verify landlord ID documents and proof of property ownership or lease agreements before a listing goes live.

2. NSFAS Matching Intelligence

- **Smart eligibility matching:** An AI-powered engine that scores listings against a student's NSFAS allowance, campus proximity, and stated preferences — going beyond simple checkbox filters.
- **Eligibility chatbot:** A conversational assistant that instantly answers student questions such as whether a given listing qualifies under their NSFAS accommodation allowance.

3. Landlord Trust Scoring

- **Aggregated trust score:** Combine verification status, review sentiment, and responsiveness metrics into a single AI-generated trust score displayed on each listing.

4. Smart Search

- **Natural language queries:** Allow students to search using everyday phrasing (e.g. “quiet place near campus under R3500”) instead of navigating rigid filter menus.
- **Auto-generated summaries:** Automatically produce concise, highlight-driven listing summaries from raw landlord-submitted descriptions.

5. Fraud Pattern Detection

- **Anomaly detection:** Identify fake reviews or coordinated scam accounts by analyzing posting behavior patterns and account activity over time.